

MUAY THAI

4-WEEK CARDIO TRAINING PLAN

Build fight-ready conditioning from scratch.
Go from gassing out in round 1 to lasting 5 full rounds.

Most Muay Thai beginners train techniques but neglect cardio — then wonder why they can't make it through a full class. This 4-week plan is built specifically around Muay Thai energy demands: short explosive bursts, active recovery, and the kind of full-body conditioning you need for real training. No gym required for most sessions.

HOW TO USE THIS PLAN

Round timing: 3 minutes on, 1 minute rest — always. This mirrors real Muay Thai round structure.

Intensity scale: RPE (Rate of Perceived Exertion) out of 10. RPE 6 = can talk but breathing hard. RPE 8 = can't hold a conversation. RPE 10 = max effort.

Rest days are mandatory. Your cardio improves during recovery, not during training.

Equipment needed: jump rope, heavy bag (optional), timer app on phone.

WEEK 1 — BUILD THE BASE

Goal: Establish your aerobic base with daily roadwork. Muay Thai fighters run every day — this is where it starts.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Roadwork — easy run	5 km	RPE 6 — conversational pace, flat route
Tue	Roadwork + jump rope	5 km + 15 min	Easy run, then 5x3 min rope with 1 min rest
Wed	Roadwork — easy run	5 km	RPE 6 — same route, focus on breathing
Thu	Roadwork + bag rounds	5 km + 20 min	Easy run, then 5x3 min bag at RPE 7
Fri	Roadwork — easy run	5 km	RPE 6 — last easy day of the week
Sat	Long slow run	8 km	RPE 5-6 — build aerobic base, no rush
Sun	REST	—	Full recovery — mandatory

Week 1 Tips:

The daily runs will feel easy — that's correct. Aerobic base takes time to build and rushing it leads to injury. Exhale on every strike during bag rounds. Never hold your breath.

WEEK 2 — BUILD VOLUME

Goal: Increase run distance and start adding intensity. Legs should feel stronger by end of week.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Roadwork — steady run	6 km	RPE 6-7 — slightly faster than week 1
Tue	Roadwork + shadowboxing	6 km + 20 min	Run, then 5x3 min shadow: jab-cross-teep non-stop
Wed	Roadwork — easy run	5 km	RPE 6 — active recovery day
Thu	Roadwork + bag rounds	6 km + 25 min	Run, then 6x3 min bag at RPE 7-8
Fri	Hill sprints + easy jog	30 min total	10x30 sec hill sprint, walk back, then 10 min jog
Sat	Long run	10 km	RPE 6 — longest run of the plan so far, steady pace
Sun	REST	—	Full recovery

Week 2 Tips:

The 10km Saturday run is your milestone. Don't race it — if you finish at a jog, that's perfect. The teep (push kick) non-stop for a full round will destroy your hip flexors in the best way.

WEEK 3 — FIGHT SIMULATION

Goal: Combine running base with fight-pace bag sessions. Train like you're preparing for a real fight.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Roadwork — interval run	6 km	2 min fast / 1 min jog alternating throughout
Tue	Roadwork + 5-round bag	5 km + 35 min	Easy run, then 5x3 min bag full pace, RPE 8-9
Wed	Roadwork — easy run	5 km	RPE 6 — active recovery, shake out the legs
Thu	Roadwork + circuit	5 km + 30 min	Run, then 4 rounds: rope/shadow/bag/burpees, 45 sec each no rest
Fri	Sprint session	30 min	10x100m full sprints, walk back — no jogging between
Sat	Long run	12 km	RPE 6-7 — push the distance, controlled effort
Sun	REST	—	Full recovery — mandatory

Week 3 Tips:

The Thursday circuit is brutal — that's the point. Muay Thai fights don't pause. The 12km Saturday run is your biggest aerobic day. If you complete it you're fight-ready on the cardio base.

WEEK 4 — PEAK & TEST

Goal: Hit peak conditioning then taper. By Friday you should last 5 full rounds without gassing.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Roadwork — interval run + bag	6 km + 25 min	1 min fast / 1 min jog throughout, then 5x3 min bag RPE 8
Tue	Roadwork — hard run	8 km	RPE 7-8 — push harder than week 1, same distance feels easier
Wed	Roadwork — easy run	5 km	RPE 6 — active recovery, flush the legs
Thu	Roadwork + shadowboxing	5 km + 20 min	Easy run, then 4x3 min shadow — clean technique, not pace
Fri	5-round bag test	35 min	5x3 min bag at RPE 9 — this is your fitness test
Sat	Long run — final	10 km	RPE 6 — run the same 10km as week 2. Notice the difference.
Sun	REST	—	Celebrate — you made it

Week 4 Tips:

Friday is your test. If you can do 5x3 min bag rounds at high intensity and still feel in control at the end, your base cardio is fight-ready. Compare how round 5 felt in week 1 vs week 4.

KEY DRILLS EXPLAINED

Teep Cardio Drill

Stand in front of the bag. Alternate left and right teeps (push kicks) for a full 3-minute round without stopping. Sounds simple — it will destroy your cardio in the best way. This replicates the leg and hip flexor demand of a real Muay Thai round.

Switch Kick Intervals

30 seconds of switch kicks at maximum speed, 30 seconds rest. Repeat 10 times. The switch kick requires a full-body rotation — it taxes your core, hips, and conditioning simultaneously.

Shadowboxing with Burpee Finish

2 minutes of shadowboxing (jab-cross-hook-teep combos), then 10 burpees immediately. No rest between. Repeat 5 times. This simulates the oxygen debt of a real fight.

Jump Rope Pyramid

1 min easy > 2 min medium > 3 min fast > 2 min medium > 1 min easy. No rest between levels. Jump rope is the single best Muay Thai cardio tool — it builds footwork, timing, and aerobic capacity simultaneously.

Clinch Conditioning

With a partner: 2 minutes of clinch work (grip fighting, knee strikes, off-balancing). No breaks. If solo: grab a heavy bag and practice pulling it toward you and driving knees for 2 minutes straight.

NUTRITION FOR MUAY THAI CARDIO

You don't need a complicated diet. Follow these basics and your training will improve:

Pre-training (1-2 hrs before)

Small meal with carbs + protein. Rice and chicken, oats with eggs, banana with peanut butter. Avoid training on a full stomach.

Post-training (within 30 min)

Protein + carbs to start recovery. Protein shake + banana, or rice and eggs. This window matters most for cardio recovery.

Hydration

Drink water consistently all day — not just during training. Dehydration kills cardio performance faster than anything. Aim for 3-4 litres on training days.

What to avoid before training

Heavy meals, alcohol, excessive caffeine. If you feel sick during bag rounds, you ate too close to training.

WHAT'S NEXT

You've built the cardio base. Now make sure your gear matches your training level. The wrong gloves, shin guards, or Thai pads can slow your progress — or worse, cause injury.

Take our free gear quiz at muaythai-gear-quiz.vercel.app and get personalized recommendations based on your training style, budget, and experience level.

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